

Epson Stylus C41SX printer

Print me pretty

The C41SX, the latest budget printer from Epson, has a cool contoured look and a great colour combination. The package includes five photo quality and three economy mode photo papers. As it has only two buttons and two LED indicators for the printer and ink status, it's easy for the new user to find his way around the printer. But one glaring drawback is the outdated parallel interface—as a result, it could not be auto detected on our test PC running Windows 2000 Professional.

We printed a combination of documents, including a full A4-sized colour photograph, a text document and a combination document which had varying fonts, colour bars, concentric circles and so on. The C41SX took just 52 seconds to print the text document, while it took 1,910 seconds (31 minutes, 50 seconds) to print the colour photograph—almost

twice as much time as taken by the slowest printers (Olivetti ArtJet 12 and 22) in our Printer comparison test in July 2002! The colour photograph was reproduced with a slight haze and the colours suffered in terms of richness. However, the combination document reproduced amazingly sharp results—even minute differences in the font sizes and colour bars were easily distinguishable. However, a big shortcoming was that the software did not show the ink level, a feature found in most printers available today.

The Epson C41SX is a good buy if price is a bigger concern for you than speed. Others, who need a more feature-rich printing device, had best look elsewhere.

SPECIFICATIONS

Parallel port, 1440x720 dpi, 12 KB input data buffer

Epson Stylus C41SX	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶

Price: Rs 3,950
Contact: Epson India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 080-5321266
E-mail: vasu@eid.epson.co.in
Web site: www.epson.com

Mercury HT4500 speakers

Sound aloud

The satellites of this discrete five-channel surround sound system are rated at 6 watts RMS and the subwoofer is powered at 20 watts RMS. The package includes sturdy speakers in a smooth black finish, speaker stands and the necessary cables for connecting the speakers to the respective connections. The subwoofer stands very firm and does not get dis-

lodged even at high volumes. The speaker performed well in our sound quality tests. It handled the low and high frequency sounds with ease. This was especially noticeable in the gaming tests where the intense music and the various sound effects were clearly reproduced.

If you already possess a DVD

player and a 5.1 channel soundcard, then this speaker would complement them well—the panning effects and the punch of the bass sounds in the movie quality test were pretty good. In our sound frequency test, the speaker was able to reproduce sounds from 30 Hz to 15 KHz without any distortion.

The sound quality in the ultimate treble test was up to the mark, but in the ultimate bass test there was considerable jarring and loss of bass at maximum volume levels.

Price: Rs 4,200
Contact: Kobian India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 080-5566626
E-mail: rohit@kobian.com
Web site: www.kobian.com

Gainward GeForce 4 Golden Sample

Go 4 gold

The Golden Sample cards from Gainward impressed us with their truly outstanding stability and performance at significantly overclocked settings. The card is built using specially chosen, hand picked components and hardware tuning techniques to offer a level of performance not ordinarily attainable by other cards made using run-of-the-mill chips and components.

We tested the card using a Pentium 4 2.8 GHz processor along with 256 MB RDRAM—even at the default clock speed, the card scored higher than what we had seen earlier. But what really hit us was the sheer power of the card to sustain performance through the high quality and anti-aliasing tests. It ran *Quake III Arena* at maximum quality settings, with 4x anti-aliasing enabled at a resolution of 1024x768 (32 bit high

All in all, this speaker set is a good choice if you already possess a 5.1 soundcard or if you plan to upgrade to one.

SPECIFICATIONS

5.1-speaker setup; power rating of 6 watts RMS per channel for satellites and 20 watts RMS for subwoofer; Front In, Rear In, Centre/Subwoofer In connectors; includes power adapter, speaker stands and cables; 30 Hz to 15 KHz frequency response range

Mercury HT4500	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶

colour, 32 bit texture depth) at over 100 fps!

We also overclocked the card and got it to run stably at 320/725 MHz (the default being 300/640 MHz), giving us a 10 per cent increase in performance. The card retails for

Rs 24,195, which is way lower than the other available GeForce 4 Ti4600 cards in the market. All said and done, it is by far the fastest card we've ever tested.

SPECIFICATIONS

nVidia GeForce 4 Ti4600 chipset, 300 MHz default core speed, 2.8ns 128 MB high-speed DDR SDRAM/SDRAM, 640 MHz (DDR) default memory speed, two DVI to CRT connectors

Gainward GeForce 4	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶

Price: Rs 24,195
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